Session 56

2026-10-25

1 - A sleepless dawn

~08:20, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. The party rouse after a night without rest; through the small hours Amidamaru has noticed doors opening quietly out in the corridor, and the shadow of feet pausing once at their own door. The tortle has felt a faint sorcerous weight settle on him as the morning begins — he recognises the shape of it but not the hand behind it.
2. Feeling the artificer's curse, Sinsong asks everyone to join hands and praise his name aloud; Amidamaru turns heel on the words and walks straight out of the room with a goodbye.
3. **Fenwick**, a lodge servant, brings in porridge, dried fruit and a small cloth bag of jerky to their sitting room. Eguzkilore sniffs for poison finding only unfamiliar spices; Nuberroca empties his bowl without inspecting it; Amidamaru pleads an upset stomach and does not eat.
4. An older hunter — **Angrath**, chief of the lodge's hunt under the late **Lord Marsten** — comes to see them off. Until the new owners took the house the goblins had never caused trouble beyond petty theft; he believes the camp lies somewhere high in the mountains to the north. He has nothing in particular against them and no interest in joining the hunt.
5. Angrath lets slip that the trolls which used to roam these woods now mostly serve the lodge's new masters; the wild ones were devoured by a white dragon who has visited the house three or four times since the new owners arrived, only to speak with the lady.
6. Mialee presses him on the dragon's schedule; Angrath has not found a pattern, only that it comes from the south-east. He names **Parnast** as the nearest town, days of travel the same way.
7. Nuberroca blurts out loud that they are cultists — cultists and adventurers, and Mialee covers for him with a cheerful *"Glory to Tiamat"*. Angrath ignores the salute and takes his leave.
8. Nuberroca calls his god's furious patronage down with a shout and a fist on the table; a blue glow runs along the old wounds at his neck and they close under it. Amidamaru adds a wash of his own healing on the goliath for good measure, the same blue light brightening along the barbarian's throat.

2 - Loose limbs

~08:50, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. On the landing above, **Talis** appears and beckons them up. Nuberroca steps outside for fresh air first — and crumples boneless across the threshold, awake but unable to move. Eguzkilore goes down next; Mialee feels the drug catch her, mouth pasty, limbs leadening.
2. From the entry hall doorway, with **Trepsin** already striding in from the east, Amidamaru throws his voice into the brute's ear — a whispered warning of goblins to the south, telling him to run; Trepsin only snorts and keeps coming.
3. Mialee weaves a word of travel and vanishes from where she stood, reappearing on the shingles of the roof overhead. From the cold tiles she lands on she glimpses a loose nest of twigs; two large feathery shapes lie coiled there at rest — perytons, the heart devourers they have faced before. She crawls under her cloak and holds there.
4. Talis arrives, **Kusphia** at her shoulder, and sends her mercenaries to carry the slumped bodies through to the breakfast room. Trepsin has to fold himself double to pass the lintel; his old mud-prints along the hall match other prints the party had seen the day before.

3 - Shackled

~09:00, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. The soldiers manacle each party member into their chair; Trepsin lifts Amidamaru across as a mountain shifts rocks. The drug catches every one of them — except the tortle, saved by his ill stomach — and it pulls the lie from anyone it takes.
2. Kusphia searches each prisoner. On Nuberroca she pulls back the cloak and finds **Torm**'s gauntleted fist on his breastplate; on Kaelthar the same symbol under his armour; on Nyx she lifts out the amulet at her throat, revealing the Harpers' sigil. Amidamaru pulls his head into his shell when her hand reaches, but Kusphia will not reach inside.
3. Talis asks who they really are, and the drug does the rest. Nuberroca blurts the whole story in one breath — Greenest, the cult, the stolen hoard, the portal, the goblin that beat him on the road. Kusphia bends to Talis's ear and names them as two likely members of the Order of the Gauntlet and a Harper.
4. Amidamaru bargains for a Thayan spellbook, one of two he kept from the Red Wizard they took it from.

4 - Common enemy

~09:30, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. Talis listens, and then names what she wants: to put right the evil in this world and see **Varram** dead — a name none of the party has ever heard — adding that if **Rezmir** should suffer in the same stroke, so much the better for them all. Amidamaru shivers at Rezmir's name and says only that he is in agreement.
2. Talis's eyes return to the Thayan book with new weight. The book changes hands for two missions: kill the Nashkag goblins to earn the cult's signs, passwords and the means to reach the **Castle in the Clouds**; and once inside, sabotage Rezmir's cargo so the shipment never reaches its destination. The party may keep whatever treasure they can lift off that cargo, and Talis will deny ever having spoken to them if they meet again after Varram is dead.
3. Amidamaru circles back to the white dragon — if he visits, will he harm them?. Talis's eyes light at the name — **Glazhael**, the great lord — and she says she would never speak on his behalf, only that so long as he bears them no grudge no harm should come to them. Pressed on when he was last there, she answers: about a tenday past, and she does not know when he will come again.
4. Above, Mialee crosses from the roof into the room where they met with Talis, and then to a bedroom she identifies as hers by the clothing and decor. She picks the lock on a chest at the foot of the bed, lifting a cache of gold and a coat of chainmail woven to shed its own pale light. When voices start up in the next room, she lowers herself from the eaves to the back garden with only a bruise and slips out to rejoin the party at the gate later.
5. Nuberroca mentions his own mission to save his village from the undead in the northern mountains, but Talis has no interest beyond the bargain already struck. Trepsin will accompany them to the goblin hunt — half escort, half watchdog, and because he enjoys the work.

5 - A thief's request

1. Waiting for the drug to clear, Nuberroca asks for a weapon for the hunt; Talis slaps him open-handed and reclaims the lightspear from the goliath's back, calling the party out as thieves.
2. Amidamaru, quiet at Talis's shoulder, asks where the truth-drug came from. She tells him to look for it in the underworld — ask the Zhentarim — and leaves them.
3. Nuberroca sets his nature book across his knees and reads it against the troll propped at the far wall. The pages tell him trolls regenerate; that they are a bog and marsh creature these mountain woods are not; and that fire cauterises their wounds and stops the regrowth.
4. Mialee uses the long wait to make some arrows in the woods, but her loose limbs hinder her, and she manages to complete a single arrow, which she lays into her quiver with the rest.
5. After around an hour, the drug finally lifts. Trepsin, who had stood cross-armed against the wall, shakes them to their feet with an open-handed slap on Nuberroca — *"you're fine"* — then hauls Amidamaru and the goliath upright by the shoulders without ceremony and marches them out.
6. On the step the brute stops to wipe something nasty off his foot — Sinsong's offering from the night before, trodden through on his way in and still exactly where it had been left.
7. He crosses to the stable and brings out two of his drakes before guiding them to the frozen forest.

6 - Going north

~10:30, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. Nuberroca manages to coax conversation out of the troll: he likes killing and Talis feeds him; he has been to Parnast, a huge city by his standards. The goliath offers a fist to bump, and Trepsin, at a loss, cups the goliath's hand in his lower palm instead.
2. On the way to the drake-stable Nuberroca tries to clamber onto the troll's shoulder, he is shoved off at every attempt. Undeterred, he presses a hand to the troll's arm anyway — *"you don't disgust me, I can touch you"* — Trepsin bewildered as to why anyone would want to.
3. Mialee drops down from the lodge roof to rejoin the party at the gate, the gold cache and the glowing coat of chainmail from Talis's chest hidden in her bag; on the march she tells Amidamaru about the haul, agreed between them that the armour not be worn until well away from the lodge.
4. Trepsin walks them north through the woods in silence, tolerating their presence in a mission he would gladly take alone with his drakes. Two hours of climbing bite with the cold, Mialee starts struggling as her fingers go numb. Nuberroca tucks her inside his furs to keep her moving.
5. Mialee catches the first glint of eyes watching them from the pines. She and Amidamaru whisper agreement, a word carried on the air between them, to let the goblins open the fight and side with them against the troll if the troll looks beaten. Over the next half hour whole handfuls of eyes become visible, enough to pick out the green points of a goblin's ear.
6. Amidamaru proposes that they ask the goblins to lay the ambush on the troll instead; Mialee agrees. Eguzkilore drifts aside and quietly asks Amidamaru what the plan is — there is none, the tortle admits. Trepsin notices some of the party have dropped behind, turns, counts them, and warns the rest: the goblins are close.

7 - Prove it

~13:00, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. Mialee weaves a floating arrow of light straight above Trepsin, inscribed 'goblins, attack him!' in a sign visible only from aloft. Amidamaru follows with an illusion of small goblin footprints laid in the snow nearby. Trepsin stops, bends to the prints, smells them and starts to track them.
2. Mialee signals Nuberroca to something glinting forty feet south — a sword jammed into the ground behind a tree. Nuberroca creeps close with her; Mialee reaches out with her ethereal hand and the hilt passes clean through — the sword is an illusion. *"This smells bad,"* she whispers, *"and for once it isn't you."* They hold off.
3. A horn sounds from behind the trees, and a scatter of goblins hurl their explosive flasks at Trepsin, most miss but three catch him square. Flames crawl across his bulk, he sweeps his cloak closed and the fire snuffs out as if it had never caught. Mialee calls out that the cloak shields from fire.
4. One of the spheres catches Fenrir as the dire-wolf slinks between trees, the fur burns and the wolf is severely wounded, but Kaelthar is unscathed. The red dragonborn stands too plain against the dark trunks and is targeted by several arrows that miss him by an inch. Between the pines Nuberroca's bulk shadows Mialee from an arrow meant for her; she bends under her cloak and takes only a graze.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee picks out the lead archer through the trees — **Sohey**, the goblin who had felled Nuberroca the day before. She projects her voice into his ear across the woods — they are not cultists, they want this troll dead too, help them. His answer comes back on the same thread: prove it.

8 - The butcher falls

1. Sohey's own cocktail smothers the last flicker on the cloak, and the goblin tribe redoubles their attacks, then melts into the trees. Sohey lifts his voice above the noise — they are not cultists, kill the butcher — and every goblin arrow turns onto the troll.
2. Kaelthar rides Fenrir in at a dead run, charges Trepsin with his sword and the hit lands. Trepsin turns on him, calling him traitor, and his claws rend the dragonborn, Amidamaru burns a quick arcane twist to spoil some of the attacks, but the paladin drops unconscious at the troll's feet nonetheless.
3. Nuberroca steps across without striking and tilts a small potion to Kaelthar's lips; the paladin's eyes open. Fenrir, torn apart by the troll, vanishes with a howl.
4. Amidamaru pins Trepsin and the two drakes under a weave of slowness; the drakes are affected but Trepsin shrugs it off with a grunt. Mialee hooks a poisoned arrow into Trepsin's flank — black veins climb his skin, he snarls, pulls the shaft out, and the veins recede as fast as they came.
5. Kaelthar's own prayer to lock Trepsin in place slides off — the compulsion finds nothing in the troll to bind to. Nuberroca hammers in with his polearm — the first swing lands, and with the second he hacks one of the four arms clean off. The severed arm clamps onto his boot on its own and will not let go.
6. Through the fight Sohey weaves between the pines to Trepsin's back and keeps the pressure up — the goblin leader darts in and out with his shortsword and scimitar, hooking it under the troll's guard and splitting the butcher's attention between front and rear whenever he turns to meet the party.
7. Tagged by the elf's arrows, Trepsin lunges past the others and comes down on Eguzkilore in a flurry of strikes. One claw drives into the rock beside him and chunks fly off, deep lines left in the stone where the troll's talons marked it. Eguzkilore barely holds, then disengages back out of the troll's reach.
8. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore steadies between two rocks and lets fly four shafts in a single breath; the last buries itself clean through Trepsin's throat. The troll claws for the shaft, gets it out, and sprays blood in a wide fan down his chest.
9. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca shouts and lets his cloud-step carry him clear across the woods, reappearing at Trepsin's back; the troll goes down to one knee under the elf's arrows, and the goliath drives his lance into the back of the neck, the spear comes clean through to the front.
10. From the undergrowth Sohey lifts a thumbs-up at Nuberroca.

9 - Smoke in the pines

~13:10, 17 Hammer 1490 DR

1. Amidamaru runs over, strips the moss cloak off the body and lights the corpse with a bolt of fire from his hand so the troll will not rise again. He examines the cloak later and finds no magic on it — just moss and filth woven over hide.
2. The two drakes do not last long. One is cut down by goblin arrows while Trepsin is still falling; the other, torn and dragging a broken leg, is finished with a single quiet shot from Mialee.
3. The severed arms scuttle about searching for prey and have to be run through and set alight; one of them scratches Eguzkilore before it stops moving. The elf walks between the pieces and sets each one burning, so none of it will knit back together.
4. Kaelthar summons Fenrir back to the world of the living. From the pines on all sides, the goblin laugh and the tribe breaks into a victory dance, jumping with their tiny arms raised.